

The Economics of Inheritance and Inter-Vivos Gifts: A Switzerland-Focused Macro Evidence Base from OECD Revenue Statistics (4300)

Eduardo Dietrich Zimmermann*

February 2026

Abstract

Inheritance and inter-vivos gifts are central mechanisms of wealth transmission and a core object of public economics: they shape inequality dynamics, interact with bequest motives, and raise fundamental questions for tax design. Switzerland is a high-leverage setting for studying these mechanisms because it combines high private wealth with strong fiscal federalism, where inheritance and gift taxes are largely cantonal.

This paper develops a Switzerland-focused empirical narrative using a harmonized long-run panel constructed from OECD Revenue Statistics for estate, inheritance and gift taxes (tax code 4300, with sub-codes 4310 and 4320 where separately reported). The empirical contribution is twofold. First, the paper benchmarks Swiss inheritance-and-gift tax revenues in levels and shares, and places 4300 within the broader property-tax mix (4000), jointly with recurrent net wealth taxes (4200) and residual property taxes. Second, it implements transparent summary statistics that quantify whether Switzerland’s position has drifted relative to peers: (i) a two-way fixed-effects “Switzerland $\times$ trend” specification, and (ii) exact placebo (randomization-inference) distributions for treated-minus-others differences computed over a long window (1990–2022) and over a recent window (2018–2022).

The goal is not to claim causal identification of Swiss policy effects from revenue aggregates. Rather, the paper provides a measurement-disciplined macro evidence base that clarifies what aggregate revenue series can and cannot tell, and that motivates a microdata agenda where cantonal variation can credibly identify behavioral mechanisms in inheritance and inter-vivos giving.

Replication package: doi:10.5281/zenodo.18649102.

Keywords: inheritance; inter-vivos gifts; bequest motives; wealth inequality; tax design; Switzerland; OECD revenue statistics.

JEL codes: H24, H31, H23, D31, D64.

*Working paper. Replication package (data, code, and outputs) is available at doi:10.5281/zenodo.18649102.

Contents

1	Introduction	4
1.1	Why start with macro revenue evidence?	4
1.2	What this paper does	4
1.3	Main message	5
1.4	Conceptual map: flows, stocks, and revenues	5
2	Institutional background: Switzerland	5
2.1	Fiscal federalism and decentralized transfer taxation	5
2.2	Why decentralization matters for behavior	5
2.3	Policy debate relevance	6
3	Related literature	6
3.1	Inheritance, wealth accumulation, and inequality	6
3.2	Bequest motives and inter-vivos gifts	6
3.3	Taxation of transfers: theory and evidence	6
3.4	Mobility and tax competition	6
4	Data and measurement	7
4.1	OECD Revenue Statistics classification and the 4300 code	7
4.2	Outcomes and constructed ratios	7
4.3	Country codes and comparators	7
5	Data diagnostics and coverage	7
5.1	Reporting heterogeneity: 4300 vs. 4310/4320	7
5.2	A geographic heatmap (Europe focus)	8
6	Descriptive evidence: Switzerland in OECD perspective	8
6.1	Time-series benchmarking: levels and shares	8
6.2	Cross-sectional dispersion (main view vs. full OECD)	8
6.3	Inheritance and gifts within the property-tax mix	10
6.4	Inside 4300: inheritance vs inter-vivos gifts	10
7	Empirical strategy	10
7.1	A descriptive Switzerland×trend model	10
7.2	Exact placebo (randomization inference) for cross-sectional differences	12
8	Results	12
8.1	Differential trends: Switzerland relative to peers	12
8.2	FE vs RE diagnostics (Hausman and CRE/Mundlak)	12
8.3	Exact placebo distributions: long window and recent window	12
8.4	Interpretation: what the results mean (and do not mean)	15
9	Robustness and sensitivity	15
9.1	Alternative benchmarks: ratio-of-means vs mean-of-ratios	15
9.2	Alternative time windows and structural breaks	15
9.3	Country-only filters	15

10 Scope, limitations, and interpretation boundaries	15
11 Conclusion	16
11.1 Future research directions	16
11.1.1 Cross-cantonal Switzerland replication	16
11.1.2 Linking revenues to flows and behavior with microdata	17
A Additional figures	20
B ISO3 glossary (country codes used in figures)	26
C Key descriptive tables (R outputs)	27
D Econometrics appendix (Stata outputs)	29
D.1 Placebo summaries	29
D.2 Descriptive tables (Stata outputs)	29

1 Introduction

Wealth transmission through inheritance and inter-vivos gifts is simultaneously a private family decision and a public economic phenomenon. Economically, transfers link lifecycle saving and precautionary motives to intergenerational persistence (Aiyagari 1994; De Nardi 2004; De Nardi and Yang 2016). Distributionally, transfers contribute to the accumulation and persistence of wealth concentration (Piketty 2014; Piketty and Zucman 2015; Saez and Zucman 2016). Normatively, transfers raise foundational questions about equality of opportunity and the design of taxes on capital and wealth (Atkinson and Stiglitz 1976; Mirrlees et al. 2011; Piketty and Saez 2013).

Switzerland is a natural focal point for these questions because inheritance and gift taxes are primarily levied at the cantonal (and sometimes communal) level, and tax rules and rates vary substantially across cantons (Eidgenössisches Finanzdepartement (EFD) 2024). This institutional setting has two first-order implications. First, it creates rich within-country variation that can be exploited for causal inference with administrative microdata. Second, it makes national-level revenue aggregates a meaningful but incomplete object: they summarize the net effect of policy heterogeneity and reforms across cantons, but they do not directly measure transfer flows.

1.1 Why start with macro revenue evidence?

The core scientific questions in this field are microeconomic: *who* gives and receives gifts, *how* bequest motives differ across households, *how* behavioral margins respond to taxes (timing, avoidance, mobility), and *what* the distributional and welfare consequences are. Aggregate revenue series cannot answer these questions directly. Nevertheless, a carefully constructed macro evidence base is useful for three reasons.

First, macro series provide a disciplined cross-country benchmark. Any narrative about Switzerland being “high-tax” or “low-tax” on inheritances and gifts should be anchored in comparable data that places Switzerland within the property-tax mix and the overall tax system. Second, macro series clarify measurement concepts and limitations. Revenues conflate tax bases, statutory schedules, exemptions, compliance, and macro denominators (GDP or total tax revenue). Making these layers explicit prevents over-interpretation and helps identify which objects must be measured with microdata. Third, macro evidence can guide empirical priorities. If inheritance-and-gift taxes are fiscally small (as a share of total tax revenue) but politically salient, the research agenda should focus on distributional incidence and behavioral margins rather than on aggregate revenue maximization.

1.2 What this paper does

Using OECD Revenue Statistics data, this paper performs four tasks:

1. **Benchmarking in levels and shares.** It documents the time series of inheritance-and-gift tax revenues (4300) in Switzerland relative to the OECD average and selected comparators, reporting both %GDP levels and shares of total tax revenue.
2. **Position in the property-tax mix.** It places 4300 within property taxes (4000), alongside recurrent net wealth taxes (4200) and other property-tax components, highlighting Switzerland’s distinctive profile.

3. **Trend summary with transparent controls.** It estimates a descriptive two-way fixed effects model that summarizes whether Switzerland’s relative position has drifted over time after absorbing common year shocks and time-invariant country differences.
4. **Cross-sectional extremeness via exact placebo.** It constructs exact placebo distributions for treated-minus-others differences in 4300 outcomes computed over 1990–2022 (principal) and 2018–2022 (robustness), providing an assumption-light depiction of Switzerland’s cross-sectional positioning.

1.3 Main message

The headline message is interpretive rather than causal: Switzerland often lies above the OECD average in levels, yet descriptive fixed-effects summaries can indicate relative convergence over time. Macro revenue data cannot identify mechanisms behind such drift. The policy-relevant mechanisms—cantonal tax competition, changes in exemptions for close relatives, tax planning and gift substitution, and mobility responses—must be investigated with Swiss microdata. The macro evidence here is designed to motivate and structure that microdata agenda.

1.4 Conceptual map: flows, stocks, and revenues

It is useful to separate three objects that are often conflated in public debates:

1. **Transfer flows.** The economic quantity of interest for many questions is the flow of intergenerational transfers: inheritances at death plus inter-vivos gifts.
2. **Wealth stocks.** Wealth stocks determine the potential size of future transfers and are central for inequality measurement.
3. **Tax revenues.** Revenues from inheritance and gift taxes combine transfer flows with schedules, exemptions, valuation rules, reporting, avoidance, and macro denominators (GDP or total tax revenue).

This paper operates at the revenue layer and uses it to discipline inferences and to specify the objects that require microdata.

2 Institutional background: Switzerland

2.1 Fiscal federalism and decentralized transfer taxation

Switzerland is a federation where cantons have broad tax autonomy. Inheritance and gift taxes are emblematic: the Swiss Confederation does not levy a broad federal inheritance tax, while most cantons levy inheritance taxes and many also levy gift taxes (Eidgenössisches Finanzdepartement (EFD) 2024). Decentralization implies that national outcomes aggregate heterogeneous policies; it also suggests that credible identification strategies should exploit within-country reforms and cross-canton comparisons rather than cross-country identification alone.

2.2 Why decentralization matters for behavior

Decentralization shapes behavioral responses in at least two ways. First, households can respond to higher transfer taxes through mobility (across cantons or before death). Second,

decentralization can foster tax competition, potentially leading to reductions or abolition of bequest taxes when cantons perceive their base to be mobile. Swiss evidence highlights how tax-competition narratives can contribute to the erosion of bequest taxes (Brüllhart and Parchet 2014). Aggregate revenue series cannot identify these mechanisms, but they can reveal their macro footprint.

2.3 Policy debate relevance

Political initiatives periodically propose introducing a federal inheritance tax at high rates for very large estates, often motivated by distributional objectives. Background material from the Swiss federal administration highlights the institutional status quo and considerations surrounding such initiatives (Eidgenössisches Finanzdepartement (EFD) 2024). Even when inheritance and gift taxes represent a small share of total revenue, they may be highly salient because they target wealth concentration and may trigger mobility and planning responses among the very wealthy.

3 Related literature

3.1 Inheritance, wealth accumulation, and inequality

Long-run evidence documents that inheritances can contribute substantially to aggregate wealth formation, particularly in periods where the return on capital exceeds growth (Piketty 2014; Piketty and Zucman 2015). Empirical work quantifies inherited wealth shares across countries and over time (Alvaredo et al. 2017). At the distributional level, evidence based on capitalized income tax data emphasizes wealth concentration dynamics (Saez and Zucman 2016). This literature motivates the study of intergenerational transfers in modern economies.

3.2 Bequest motives and inter-vivos gifts

Transfers reflect heterogeneous motives. Some are accidental, arising from precautionary saving under longevity and health risk (Aiyagari 1994; De Nardi 2004). Others are intentional, driven by altruism, strategic considerations, or legacy preferences (Bernheim 1991; Kopczuk and Lupton 2007). Inter-vivos gifts can serve multiple purposes and can substitute for bequests; tax policy can affect the timing of transfers (Joulfaian 2004). Understanding motives and substitution patterns is essential for interpreting transfer taxation.

3.3 Taxation of transfers: theory and evidence

Transfer taxation sits within broader public finance. Classic results on tax structure provide a baseline (Atkinson and Stiglitz 1976; Mirrlees et al. 2011). Inheritance taxation has been studied as an instrument to address intergenerational inequality and as a tax on a potentially less distortive base depending on motives and elasticities (Piketty and Saez 2013; Farhi and Werning 2013). Surveys emphasize avoidance and planning behavior and the difficulty of separating base changes from schedule changes in revenue data (Kopczuk 2009; Cremer and Pestieau 2011).

3.4 Mobility and tax competition

A large empirical literature studies migration responses to taxes (Kleven et al. 2013; Young and Varner 2011; Moretti and Wilson 2017). Switzerland is institutionally distinct but highly

relevant: cantonal autonomy makes mobility a salient concern for transfer taxation, and Swiss evidence links bequest tax erosion to tax-competition narratives (Brühlhart and Parchet 2014).

4 Data and measurement

4.1 OECD Revenue Statistics classification and the 4300 code

The core data source is OECD Revenue Statistics, which classifies taxes in a harmonized system. Estate, inheritance and gift taxes are grouped under code 4300; subcode 4310 covers estate and inheritance taxes and 4320 covers gift taxes where separately reported (OECD 2024; OECD et al. 2024). Property taxes are grouped under 4000 and include recurrent taxes on net wealth (4200) and other property-tax components.

4.2 Outcomes and constructed ratios

The paper focuses on two outcomes:

1. **Level:** T_{4300} , the 4300 revenue as a percent of GDP.
2. **Share:** $100 \times T_{4300} / _T$, the 4300 share of total tax revenue (constructed from T_{4300} and total tax revenue $_T$).

To interpret 4300 in the property-tax system, the analysis also uses within-4000 shares (e.g., T_{4300}/T_{4000} and T_{4200}/T_{4000}). These ratios clarify whether a country relies primarily on recurrent wealth taxation, recurrent immovable property taxation, or transfer taxation to raise property-related revenue.

4.3 Country codes and comparators

Figures use ISO3 country codes (e.g., CHE for Switzerland) to ensure readability across plots and tables. A code-to-name glossary generated by the replication package is provided in Appendix B.

5 Data diagnostics and coverage

Cross-country work on inheritance and gift taxation faces comparability challenges. Countries differ in (i) central vs. subnational taxation; (ii) whether gifts are taxed and separately reported; (iii) valuation and exemptions; and (iv) reporting practices. The OECD interpretative guide emphasizes that classification harmonizes categories, while institutional heterogeneity remains (OECD 2024; OECD et al. 2024).

5.1 Reporting heterogeneity: 4300 vs. 4310/4320

Many countries report 4300 without a clean split into 4310 (inheritance/estate) and 4320 (gifts). This may reflect integrated regimes, absence of gift taxation, or limited reporting. Accordingly:

- The main descriptive and econometric summaries focus on 4300, which has broader availability.
- The inheritance-vs-gifts decomposition is presented as descriptive and conditional on reporting.

- When gifts are not separately reported, the “gifts” component should be interpreted as “not separately identified” rather than as true zero gifts.

5.2 A geographic heatmap (Europe focus)

To visualize the cross-sectional pattern in recent years with a Switzerland-centered geographic lens, the replication package produces a Europe-focused choropleth map for the 2018–2022 average 4300 share of total tax revenue (when map dependencies are available), with a Tableau-ready fallback table otherwise.

Inheritance & gift taxes (4300) across OECD members (Europe focus)

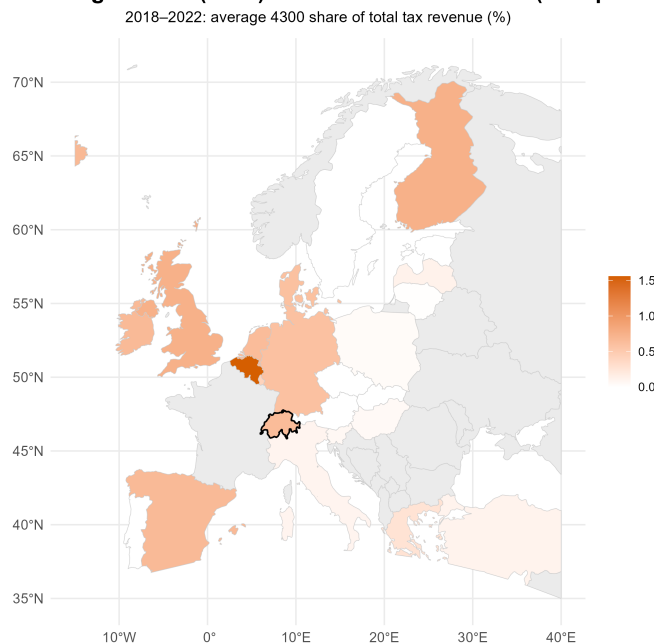


Figure 1: OECD inheritance & gift taxes (4300): Europe-focused map of 2018–2022 average share of total tax revenue (where available).

6 Descriptive evidence: Switzerland in OECD perspective

6.1 Time-series benchmarking: levels and shares

Figure 2 reports two panels: (i) T_{4300} as % of GDP, and (ii) T_{4300} as a share of total tax revenue. Switzerland is highlighted against the OECD aggregate and a small set of comparators.

6.2 Cross-sectional dispersion (main view vs. full OECD)

Inheritance-and-gift tax shares vary widely across countries. Figure 3 reports the main view (top 15 by median plus Switzerland, OECD aggregate, and comparators). Appendix Figure 9 reports the full OECD distribution to avoid any interpretation of cherry-picking. Appendix Figure 8 provides an additional scatter view of cross-sectional positioning.

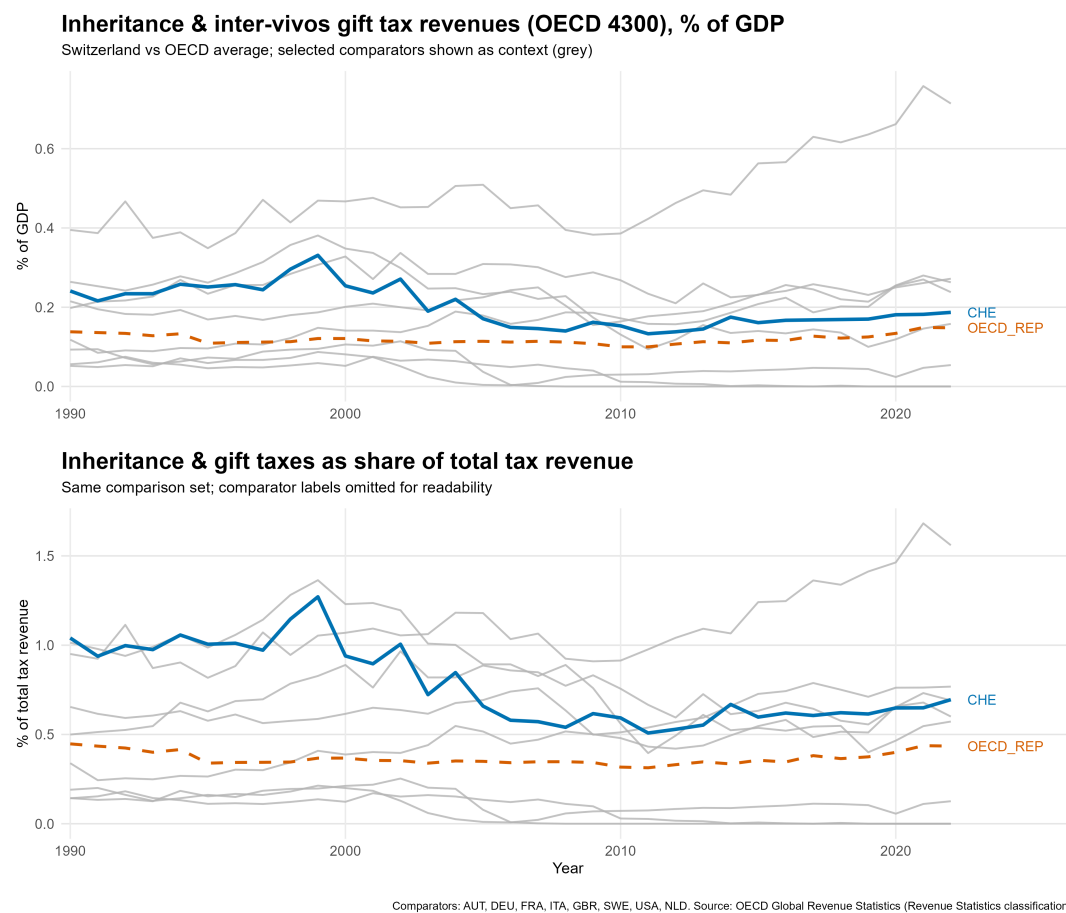


Figure 2: Inheritance & gift tax revenues (4300): Switzerland vs. OECD aggregate and selected comparators (levels and shares).

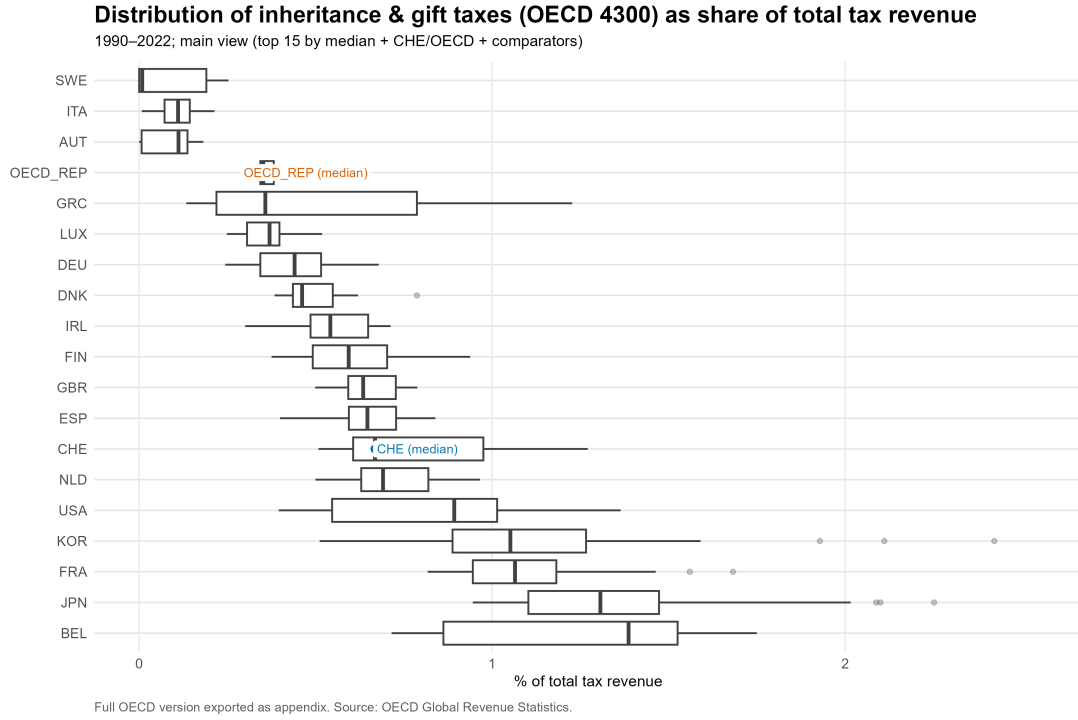


Figure 3: Distribution of 4300 as share of total tax revenue (1990–2022): main view (top 15 by median + key comparators).

6.3 Inheritance and gifts within the property-tax mix

Inheritance and gift taxes are one component of property taxation. Figure 4 shows the 2018–2022 average property-tax mix (within 4000): net wealth taxes (4200), inheritance & gifts (4300), and residual property taxes. Appendix Figure 10 reports the full OECD version for 2018–2022; Appendix Figure 11 reports the full OECD version for 1990–2022 averages.

6.4 Inside 4300: inheritance vs inter-vivos gifts

Where separately reported, 4300 can be decomposed into inheritance/estate (4310) and gifts (4320). Figure 5 reports the main view for 2018–2022; appendix figures provide full OECD views and long-window averages. When gifts are not separately reported, the “gifts” component should be interpreted as a residual “not separately identified” component rather than a true zero.

7 Empirical strategy

7.1 A descriptive Switzerland×trend model

To summarize whether Switzerland’s position has drifted relative to peers after absorbing common shocks, the paper estimates a two-way fixed effects specification:

$$y_{ct} = \alpha_c + \delta_t + \beta(1\{c = \text{CHE}\} \times (t - t_0)) + \varepsilon_{ct},$$

where y_{ct} is T_{4300} (% of GDP) or the 4300 share of total tax revenue; α_c are country fixed effects; δ_t are year fixed effects; and t_0 is a baseline year. The parameter β captures the

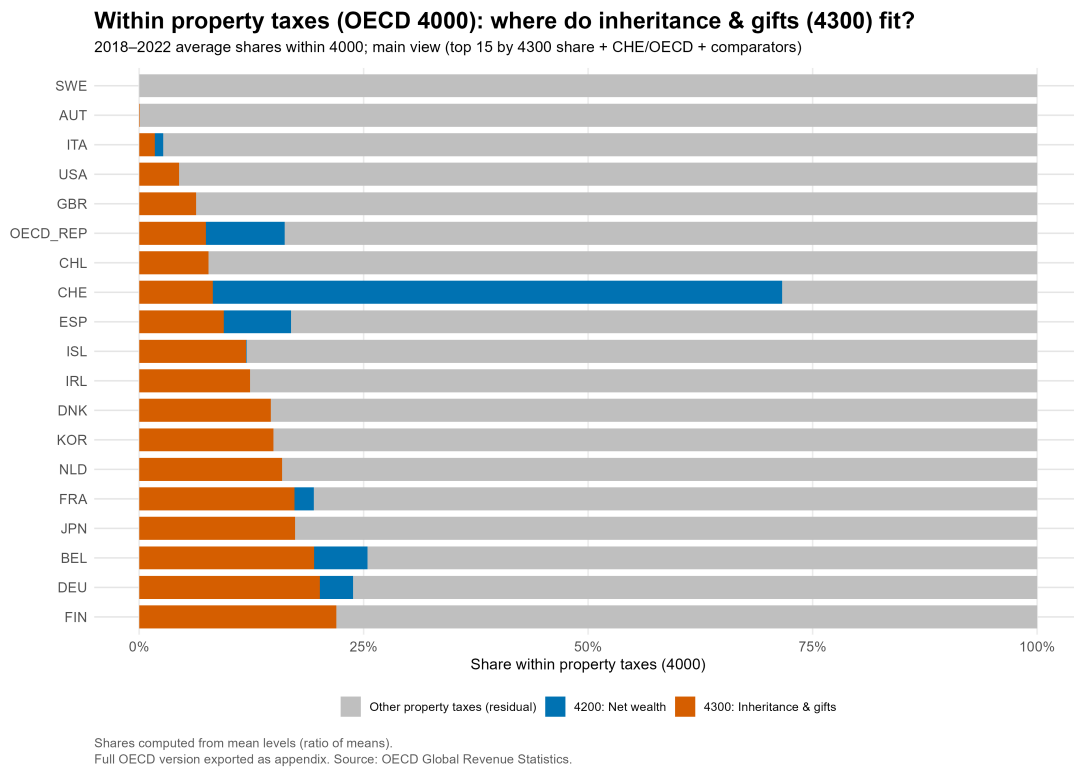


Figure 4: Property-tax mix (within 4000): 2018–2022 average shares (main view).

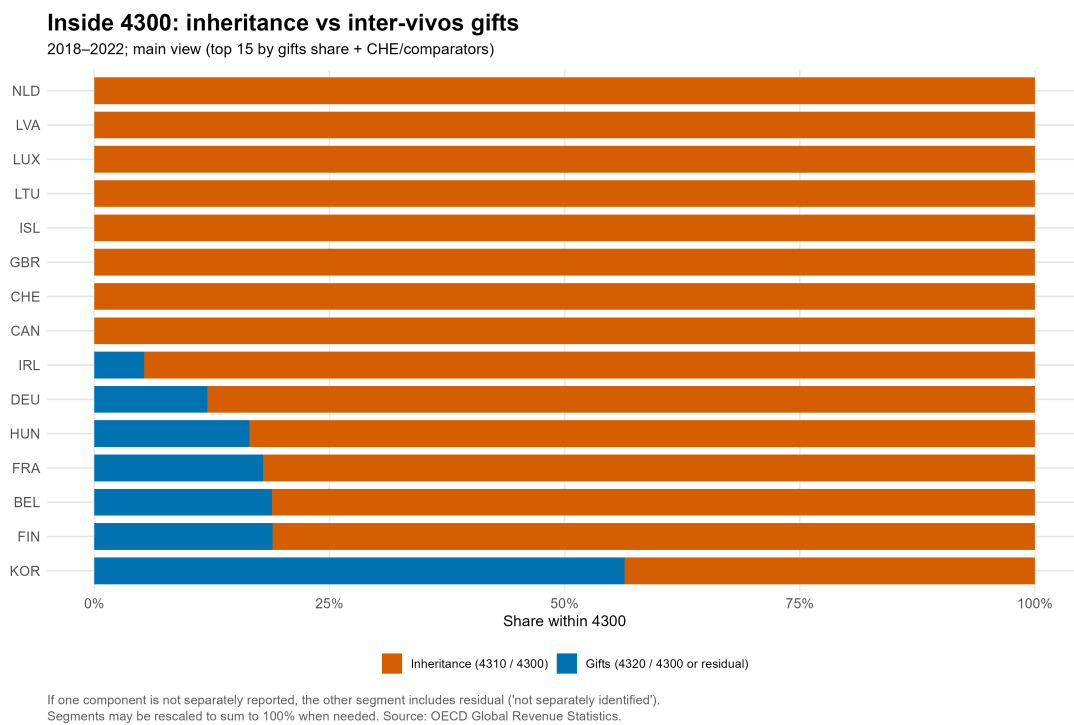


Figure 5: Inside 4300 (2018–2022): inheritance (4310) vs inter-vivos gifts (4320), where separately reported (main view).

Switzerland-specific differential linear trend relative to the common year effects. Standard errors are clustered by country.

This specification is a compact descriptive summary. It is not a causal estimate of a specific reform; it is used to communicate whether Switzerland has converged toward or diverged from the common international pattern after netting out global year shocks and time-invariant country differences.

7.2 Exact placebo (randomization inference) for cross-sectional differences

To assess whether Switzerland is an outlier without relying on parametric approximations, the paper constructs treated-minus-others mean differences and an exact placebo distribution by treating each country as Switzerland once. Two windows are reported:

1. **1990–2022 (principal)**: a long-window summary that emphasizes long-run positioning.
2. **2018–2022 (robustness)**: a recent-window summary aligned with contemporary cross-sectional comparisons.

Exact two-sided p-values are computed as the share of placebo differences with absolute value at least as large as Switzerland’s observed difference.

8 Results

8.1 Differential trends: Switzerland relative to peers

Table 1 reports the $\text{Switzerland} \times \text{trend}$ coefficient from the two-way fixed-effects specification, along with comparison specifications (RE and pooled OLS with year effects) produced by the Stata replication do-file.

Table 1: Specification comparison: $\text{Switzerland} \times \text{trend}$ coefficient (Stata outputs).

Outcome	Specification	Term	b	s.e.	p	N
"T_4300"	"FE + year FE (cluster)"	"CHE x trend"	−0.0044	0.0008	0	1,219
"T_4300"	"RE + year FE (cluster)"	"CHE x trend"	−0.0042	0.0008	0	1,219
"T_4300"	"OLS + year FE (cluster)"	"CHE x trend"	0.0029	0.0012	0.0201	1,219
"share4300_total"	"FE + year FE (cluster)"	"CHE x trend"	−0.0183	0.0022	0	1,219
"share4300_total"	"RE + year FE (cluster)"	"CHE x trend"	−0.0176	0.0022	0	1,219
"share4300_total"	"OLS + year FE (cluster)"	"CHE x trend"	0.0158	0.0032	0	1,219

8.2 FE vs RE diagnostics (Hausman and CRE/Mundlak)

Because FE/RE comparisons can be sensitive to specification details, the replication package exports both a simple Hausman test (without year dummies to avoid negative chi-squared pathologies) and an additional CRE/Mundlak-style diagnostic.

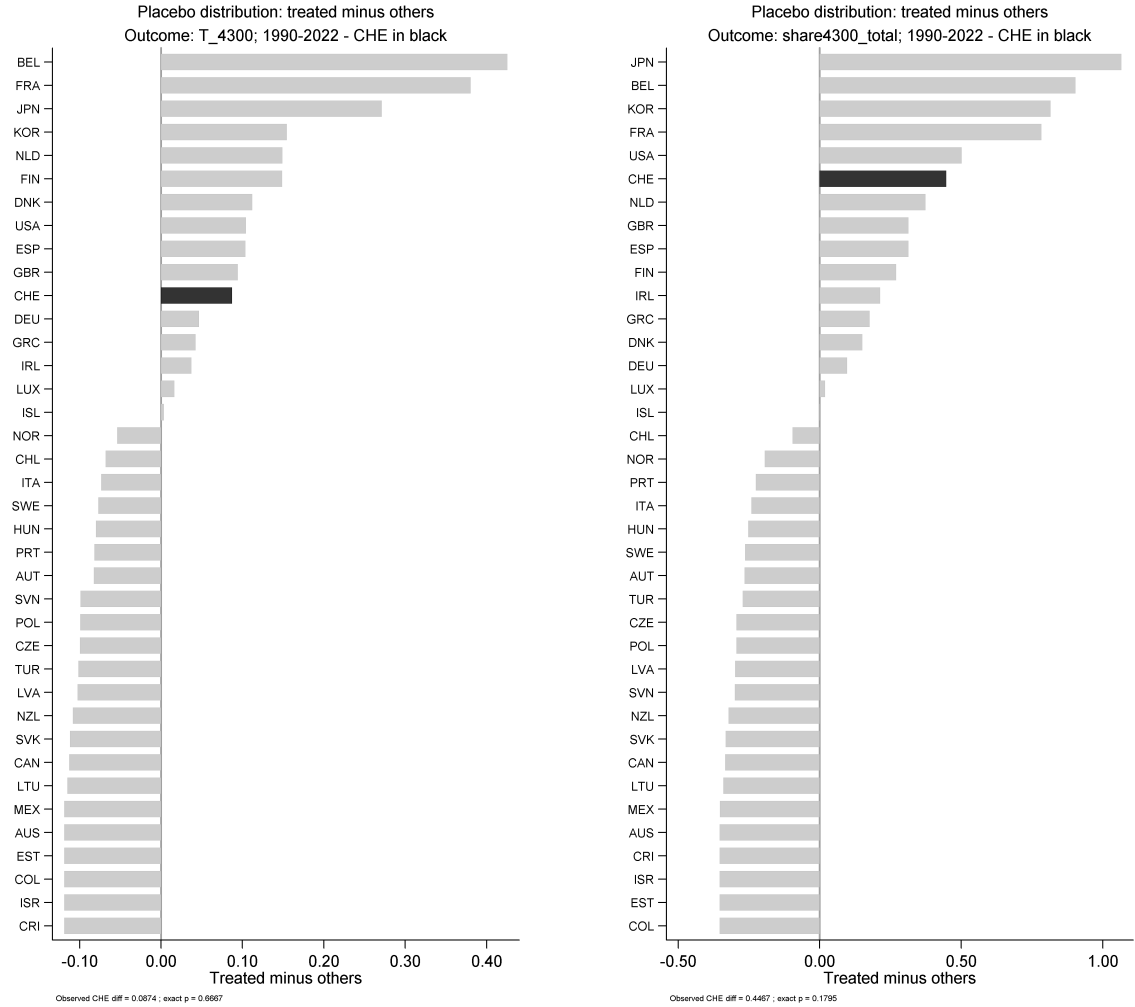
8.3 Exact placebo distributions: long window and recent window

Figures 6 and 7 report placebo distributions for two outcomes: T_{4300} (%GDP) and the 4300 share of total tax revenue.

Table 2: FE vs RE diagnostics (Stata outputs).

Outcome	Specification	χ^2	df	p
"T_4300"	"y c_year + CHE*c_year; FE vs RE (simple)"	7.5356	2	0.0231
"share4300_total"	"y c_year + CHE*c_year; FE vs RE (simple)"	10.2793	2	0.0059

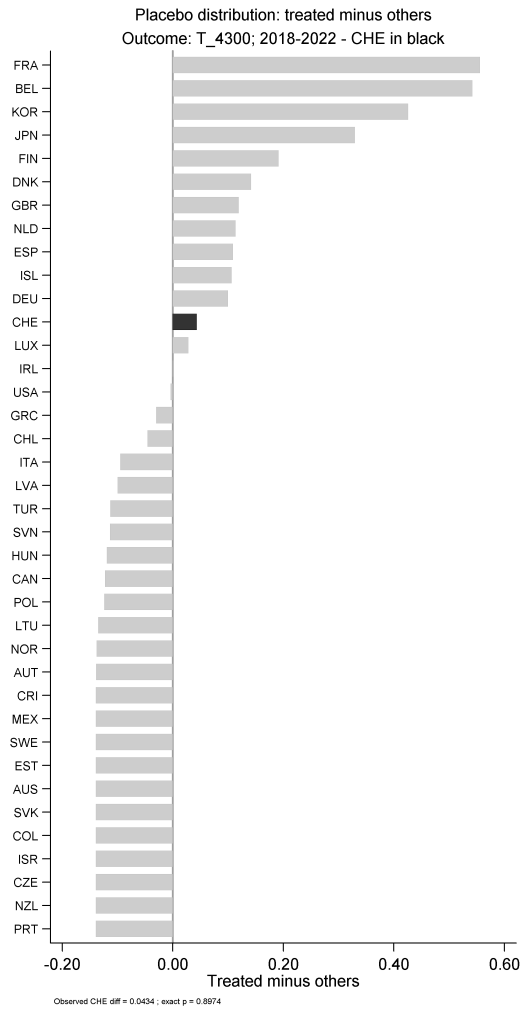
Outcome	Test	p	N
"T_4300"	"Mundlak/CRE: joint test of unit-mean terms"	0.0227	1,219
"share4300_total"	"Mundlak/CRE: joint test of unit-mean terms"	0.0057	1,219



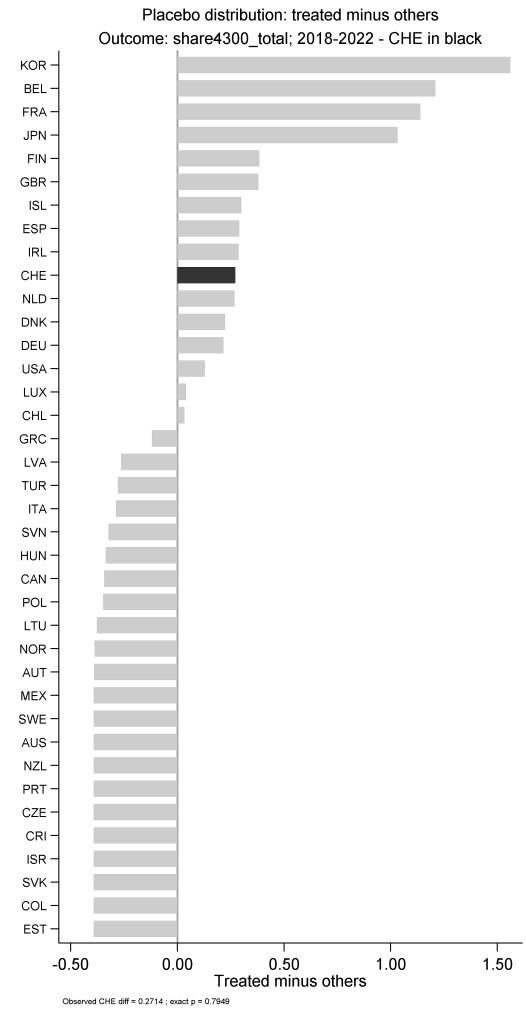
(a) T_{4300} (%GDP), 1990–2022

(b) 4300 share of total tax, 1990–2022

Figure 6: Exact placebo distributions (principal window). Switzerland highlighted in each panel.



(a) T_{4300} (%GDP), 2018–2022



(b) 4300 share of total tax, 2018–2022

Figure 7: Exact placebo distributions (recent window). Switzerland highlighted in each panel.

8.4 Interpretation: what the results mean (and do not mean)

The results support bounded conclusions. First, Switzerland’s macro positioning can be benchmarked transparently in levels, shares, and within the property-tax mix. Second, compact descriptive summaries can indicate whether Switzerland exhibits relative convergence or divergence once common year shocks and time-invariant country differences are netted out. However, because revenues confound bases and schedules and are affected by compliance, valuation, and avoidance, these patterns do not identify changes in inheritance flows, do not reveal bequest motives, and do not isolate behavioral responses. They should be read as disciplined macro context and motivation for microdata analysis.

9 Robustness and sensitivity

9.1 Alternative benchmarks: ratio-of-means vs mean-of-ratios

Group benchmarks can be constructed as ratio-of-means (compute group means of numerator and denominator then take shares) or as mean-of-ratios (compute country-level shares then average). These answer distinct questions. The replication package adopts internally consistent constructions for the main time-series benchmarking and reports cross-sectional distributions explicitly to separate accounting from dispersion.

9.2 Alternative time windows and structural breaks

The two-way FE specification imposes a linear differential trend. This is a convenient summary but may be misleading if Switzerland’s path contains structural breaks or if the global trajectory is nonlinear. The replication structure supports windowed trends and event-style designs; in a Swiss setting, those extensions are substantially more informative at the canton-year level rather than at the country-year level.

9.3 Country-only filters

Depending on the OECD extract, non-country aggregates can appear. The replication do-file filters to ISO3 country codes (with OECD aggregate handled explicitly) to avoid contaminating “others” benchmarks and placebo distributions.

10 Scope, limitations, and interpretation boundaries

This paper is designed as a complete macro evidence base rather than as a causal policy evaluation. Its scope and limitations are explicit:

1. **Revenues are outcomes, not primitives.** OECD revenue series reflect bases, schedules, exemptions, valuation rules, compliance, avoidance/planning, and macro denominators. Consequently, they do not identify transfer flows or behavioral elasticities.
2. **Subnational aggregation.** In Switzerland, 4300 aggregates heterogeneous cantonal regimes. National series are meaningful for fiscal footprint but are not the right unit for identifying cantonal mechanisms.

3. **Reporting heterogeneity for 4310/4320.** Gifts are not consistently separately reported. “Zero” in 4320 should not be interpreted as “no gifting” without institutional validation; it often means “not separately identified”.
4. **No weighting by size in the baseline.** Unweighted cross-country benchmarks describe the “typical” OECD member. Size-weighted benchmarks (by GDP or population) are informative but represent a distinct object; they are left as an extension.
5. **Macro-level identification is not attempted.** The two-way FE and placebo exercises are descriptive summaries and should not be interpreted as identifying causal effects of policy changes.

11 Conclusion

Inheritance and inter-vivos gifts are central to the transmission of wealth and to policy debates on inequality, opportunity, and capital taxation. Switzerland is a high-leverage setting for studying these mechanisms because transfer taxation is largely decentralized and operates alongside recurrent net wealth taxation within a broader property-tax system.

This paper builds a Switzerland-focused *macro evidence base* from OECD Revenue Statistics (tax code 4300). The replication package constructs a harmonized long-run country-year panel, documents coverage and reporting heterogeneity (including the limited availability of separate 4310/4320 reporting), and produces a consistent set of figures and tables that locate Switzerland within the OECD distribution. The descriptive analysis proceeds in four steps: (i) time-series benchmarking of 4300 revenues in levels (%GDP) and as shares of total tax revenue; (ii) positioning of 4300 within the property-tax mix (4000), alongside recurrent net wealth taxes (4200) and residual property taxes; (iii) a compact two-way fixed-effects Switzerland $\times$ trend specification that summarizes relative drift after absorbing common year shocks and time-invariant country differences; and (iv) exact placebo (randomization-inference) distributions for treated-minus-others mean differences over a long window (1990–2022) and a recent window (2018–2022), reported for both levels and shares.

The substantive output is interpretive rather than causal. Revenue aggregates provide a disciplined way to benchmark fiscal footprints and cross-country positioning, but they confound transfer flows with statutory schedules, exemptions, valuation, compliance, and avoidance/planning. In a decentralized setting, national 4300 revenues are informative about the *aggregate* footprint of heterogeneous cantonal regimes, yet they are not the right unit for identifying behavioral mechanisms. For that reason, the paper treats macro evidence as context and measurement discipline: it clarifies what aggregate revenue series can and cannot speak to, and it specifies the objects that must be measured with microdata to answer core questions about bequest motives, inter-vivos giving, and behavioral responses to transfer taxation.

11.1 Future research directions

Two extensions follow naturally from the measurement structure developed here.

11.1.1 Cross-cantonal Switzerland replication

The macro objects in this paper (levels, shares, and property-tax mix positioning) can be reproduced within Switzerland at the canton level using cantonal fiscal accounts and administrative

tax records. This would shift the unit from country-year to canton-year, making decentralization a source of identification rather than a source of aggregation noise. Such an extension can also clarify the joint role of wealth taxation (4200-type mechanisms) and transfer taxation in Swiss fiscal design.

11.1.2 Linking revenues to flows and behavior with microdata

The key scientific agenda is to measure inheritance flows and inter-vivos gifts directly and to estimate behavioral responses to cantonal policy variation (timing, avoidance/planning, and mobility). A macro–micro reconciliation step (aggregating micro liabilities to match canton and national revenues) provides a disciplined validation benchmark.

References

- Aiyagari, S. Rao (1994). “Uninsured Idiosyncratic Risk and Aggregate Saving”. In: *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 109.3, pp. 659–684.
- Alvaredo, Facundo, Bertrand Garbinti, and Thomas Piketty (2017). “On the Share of Inheritance in Aggregate Wealth: Europe and the USA, 1900–2010”. In: *Economica* 84.334, pp. 239–260.
- Atkinson, Anthony B. and Joseph E. Stiglitz (1976). “The Design of Tax Structure: Direct versus Indirect Taxation”. In: *Journal of Public Economics* 6.1-2, pp. 55–75.
- Bernheim, B. Douglas (1991). “How Strong Are Bequest Motives? Evidence Based on Estimates of the Demand for Life Insurance and Annuities”. In: *Journal of Political Economy* 99.5, pp. 899–927.
- Brühlhart, Marius and Raphaël Parchet (2014). “Alleged Tax Competition: The Mysterious Death of Bequest Taxes in Switzerland”. In: *Journal of Public Economics* 111, pp. 63–78.
- Cremer, Helmuth and Pierre Pestieau (2011). “Wealth Transfer Taxation: A Survey”. In: *International Tax and Public Finance* 18.2, pp. 197–220.
- De Nardi, Mariacristina (2004). “Wealth Inequality and Intergenerational Links”. In: *Review of Economic Studies* 71.3, pp. 743–768.
- De Nardi, Mariacristina and Fang Yang (2016). “Bequests and Heterogeneity in Retirement Wealth”. In: *European Economic Review* 87, pp. 100–116.
- Eidgenössisches Finanzdepartement (EFD) (2024). *Erbschafts- und Schenkungssteuer (JUSO-Initiative): Hintergrund, Fakten, Dokumente*. <https://www.efd.admin.ch/de/abstimmung-juso-initiative>. Accessed 2026-02-13.
- Farhi, Emmanuel and Iván Werning (2013). “Estate Taxation with Altruism Heterogeneity”. In: *American Economic Review* 103.6, pp. 489–522.
- Joulfaian, David (2004). “Gifts and Bequests: The Role of the Estate and Gift Tax”. In: *National Tax Journal* 57.4, pp. 743–766.
- Kleven, Henrik Jacobsen, Camille Landais, and Emmanuel Saez (2013). “Taxation and International Migration of Superstars: Evidence from the European Football Market”. In: *American Economic Review* 103.5, pp. 1892–1924.
- Kopczuk, Wojciech (2009). “Economics of Estate Taxation: A Brief Review of Theory and Evidence”. In: *Tax Law Review* 63, pp. 139–157.
- Kopczuk, Wojciech and Joseph P. Lupton (2007). “To Leave or Not to Leave: The Distribution of Bequest Motives”. In: *Review of Economic Studies* 74.1, pp. 207–235.
- Mirrlees, James A., Stuart Adam, Timothy Besley, Richard Blundell, Stephen Bond, Robert Chote, Malcolm Gammie, Paul Johnson, Gareth Myles, and James Poterba, eds. (2011). *Tax by Design: The Mirrlees Review*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Moretti, Enrico and Daniel J. Wilson (2017). “The Effect of State Taxes on the Geographical Location of Top Earners: Evidence from Star Scientists”. In: *American Economic Review* 107.7, pp. 1858–1903.
- OECD (2024). *Revenue Statistics Interpretative Guide (tax classification)*. Annex A in OECD, ATAF, and AUC 2024. Tax code 4300: Estate, inheritance and gift taxes (4310, 4320).
- OECD, ATAF, and AUC (2024). *Revenue Statistics in Africa 2024: Special Feature: Taxing Property*. Tech. rep. Includes OECD Revenue Statistics Interpretative Guide (Annex A). OECD Publishing.
- Piketty, Thomas (2014). *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

- Piketty, Thomas and Emmanuel Saez (2013). “A Theory of Optimal Inheritance Taxation”. In: *Econometrica* 81.5, pp. 1851–1886.
- Piketty, Thomas and Gabriel Zucman (2015). “Wealth and Inheritance in the Long Run”. In: *Handbook of Income Distribution*. Ed. by Anthony B. Atkinson and François Bourguignon. Vol. 2B. Elsevier, pp. 1303–1368.
- Saez, Emmanuel and Gabriel Zucman (2016). “Wealth Inequality in the United States Since 1913: Evidence from Capitalized Income Tax Data”. In: *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 131.2, pp. 519–578.
- Young, Cristobal and Charles Varner (2011). “Millionaire Migration and State Taxation of Top Incomes: Evidence from a Natural Experiment”. In: *National Tax Journal* 64.2, pp. 255–284.

A Additional figures

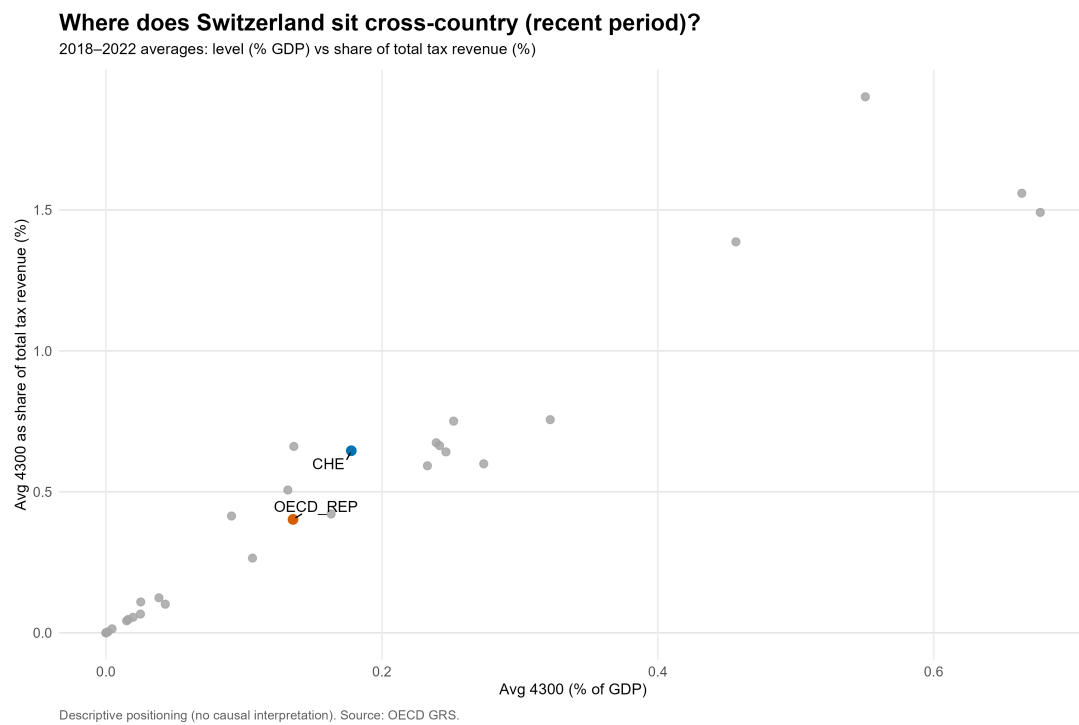


Figure 8: Cross-sectional positioning (2018–2022 averages): Switzerland highlighted.

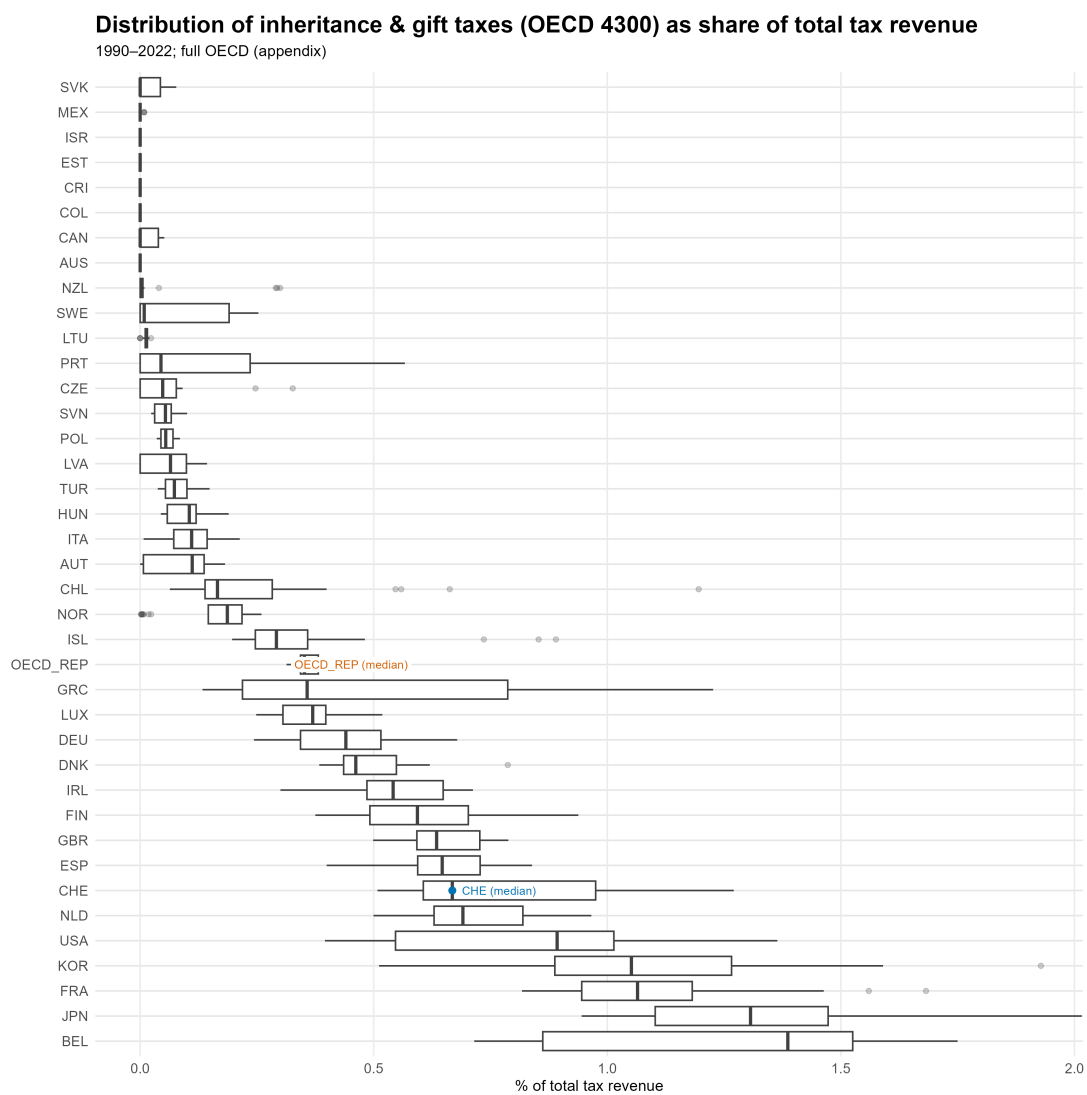


Figure 9: Distribution of 4300 share of total tax revenue (1990–2022): full OECD (appendix).

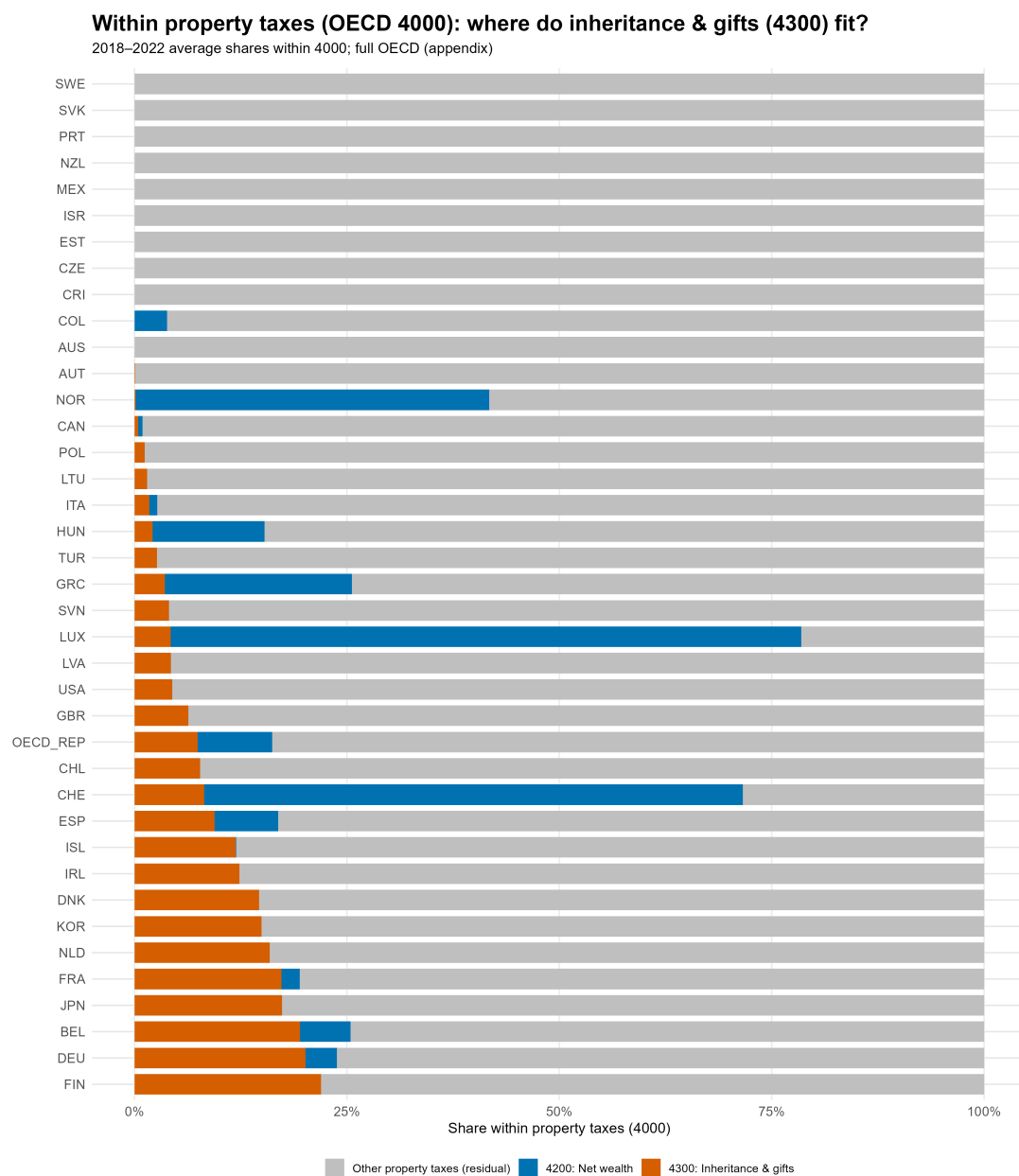


Figure 10: Property-tax mix (within 4000): 2018–2022 average shares (full OECD).

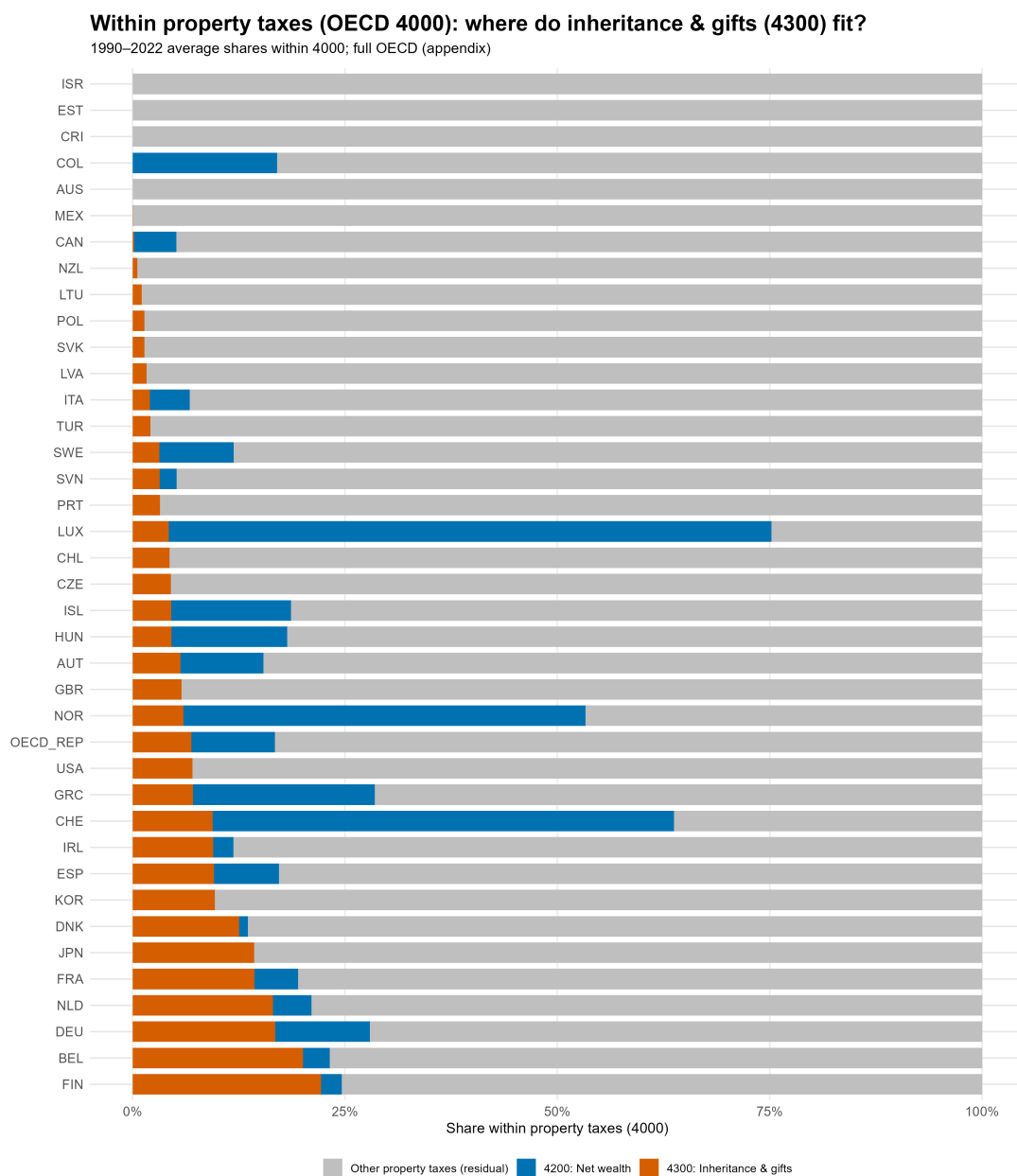


Figure 11: Property-tax mix (within 4000): 1990–2022 average shares (full OECD).

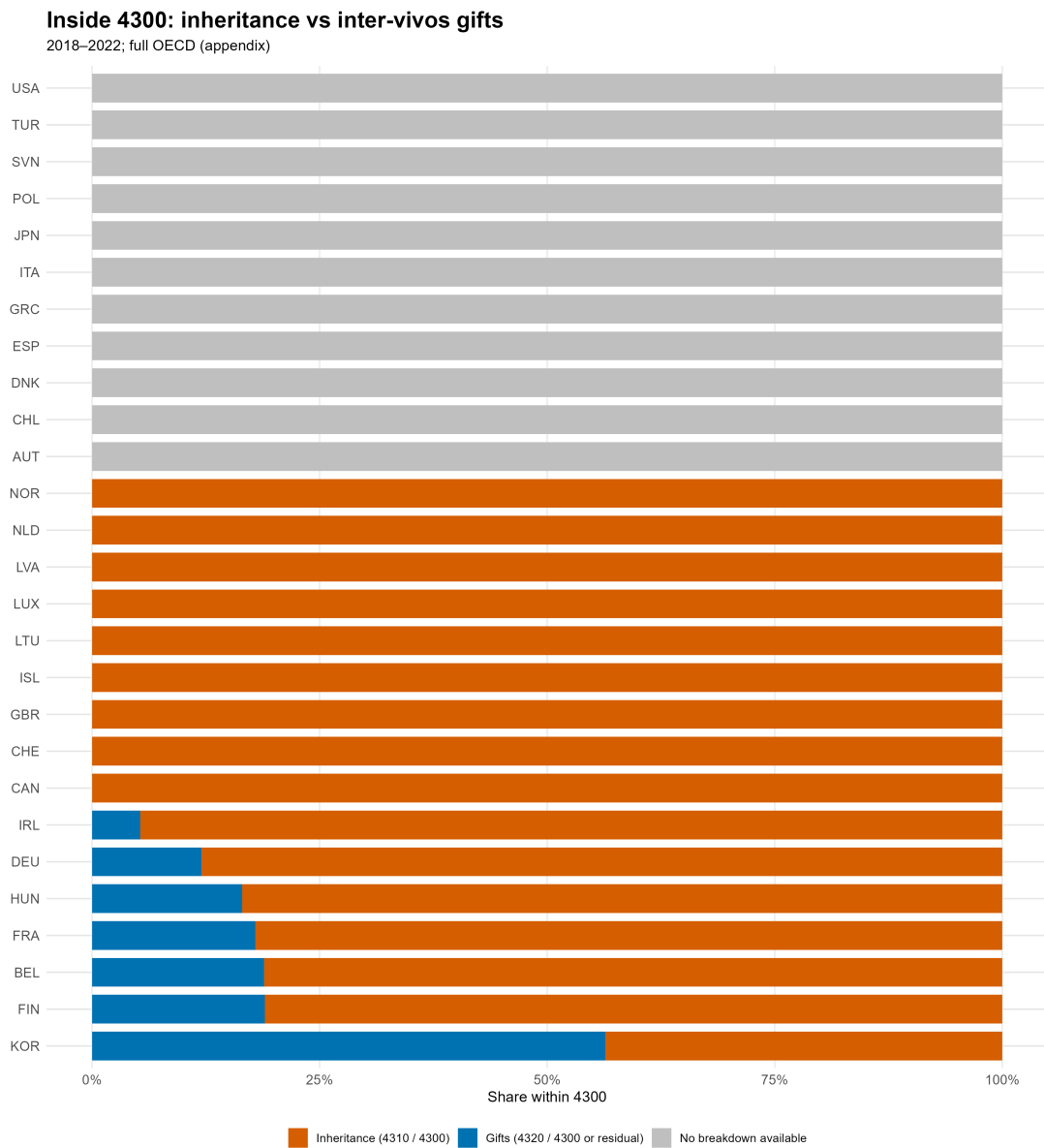
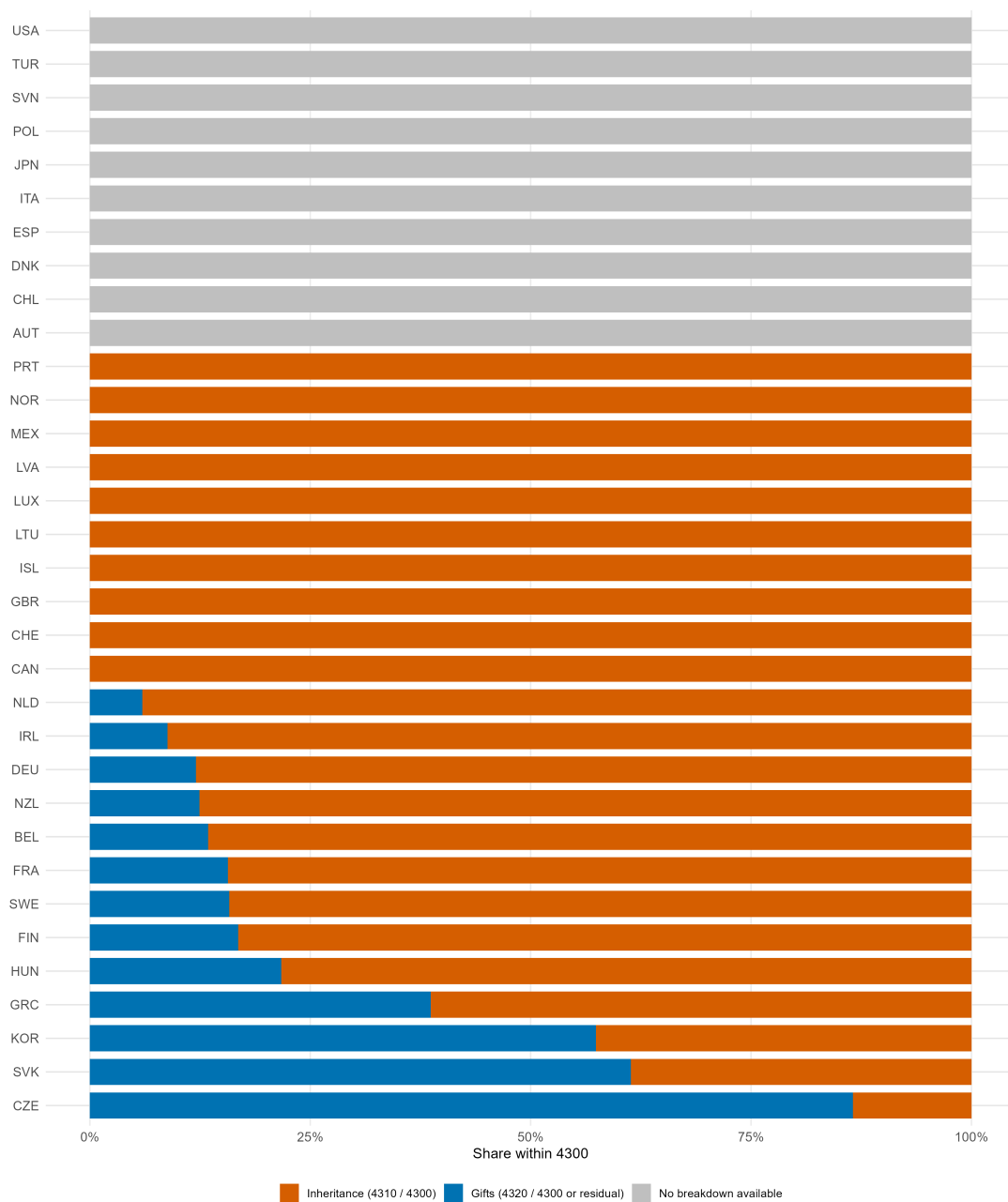


Figure 12: Inside 4300 (2018–2022): inheritance vs gifts (full OECD; where separately reported).

Inside 4300: inheritance vs inter-vivos gifts

1990–2022; full OECD (appendix)



If one component is not separately reported, the other segment includes residual ('not separately identified'); grey indicates no 4310/4320 breakdown. Segments may be rescaled to sum to 100% when needed. Source: OECD Global Revenue Statistics.

Figure 13: Inside 4300 (1990–2022): inheritance vs gifts (full OECD; where separately reported).

B ISO3 glossary (country codes used in figures)

Table 3: ISO3 country codes used in figures.

Code	Country
AUS	Australia
AUT	Austria
BEL	Belgium
CAN	Canada
CHE	Switzerland
CHL	Chile
COL	Colombia
CRI	Costa Rica
CZE	Czechia
DEU	Germany
DNK	Denmark
ESP	Spain
EST	Estonia
FIN	Finland
FRA	France
GBR	United Kingdom
GRC	Greece
HUN	Hungary
IRL	Ireland
ISL	Iceland
ISR	Israel
ITA	Italy
JPN	Japan
KOR	Korea
LTU	Lithuania
LUX	Luxembourg
LVA	Latvia
MEX	Mexico
NLD	Netherlands
NOR	Norway
NZL	New Zealand
OECD_REP	OECD average country
POL	Poland
PRT	Portugal
SVK	Slovak Republic
SVN	Slovenia
SWE	Sweden
TUR	Türkiye
USA	United States

C Key descriptive tables (R outputs)

Table 4: 2018–2022 averages: levels and shares (main view).

Code	T_{4300} (% GDP)	4300 share total tax (%)	4300 within 4000 (%)	4000 share total tax (%)
KOR	0.5504	1.9192	14.9378	12.8477
BEL	0.6638	1.5592	19.4708	8.0077
FRA	0.6772	1.4909	17.3108	8.6123
JPN	0.4566	1.3896	17.348	8.0103
FIN	0.322	0.7562	21.9436	3.4461
GBR	0.252	0.7513	6.3336	11.8616
ISL	0.2394	0.6735	11.9152	5.6521
ESP	0.2418	0.6659	9.4276	7.0634
IRL	0.1362	0.662	12.3526	5.3593
CHE	0.1778	0.6456	8.2056	7.8679
NLD	0.2464	0.6418	15.9194	4.0314
DNK	0.2738	0.6004	14.6495	4.0985
DEU	0.233	0.5926	20.114	2.9461
USA	0.1318	0.5082	4.4542	11.4085
CHL	0.091	0.4224	7.7289	5.4655
OECD_REP	0.1356	0.4025	7.4179	5.4262
ITA	0.043	0.1015	1.7542	5.7843
AUT	0.0004	0.0009	0.0693	1.3505
SWE	0	0	0	2.2067

Table 5: 2018–2022 split within 4300: inheritance vs gifts (main view; where available).

Code	Inheritance share	Gifts share	Reporting note
KOR	0.4362	0.5638	
FIN	0.8103	0.1897	
BEL	0.8111	0.1889	
FRA	0.8205	0.1795	
HUN	0.8351	0.1649	
DEU	0.8799	0.1201	
IRL	0.9471	0.0529	
CAN	1	0	
CHE	1	0	CHE: gifts not separately reported (residual used)
GBR	1	0	
ISL	1	0	
LTU	1	0	
LUX	1	0	
LVA	1	0	
NLD	1	0	

D Econometrics appendix (Stata outputs)

D.1 Placebo summaries

Table 6: Placebo summary: T_{4300} (%GDP).

Period	Outcome	CHE mean	Other mean	Diff. (CHE–Other)	p (two-sided)
"1990-2022"	"T_4300"	0.2009	0.1135	0.0874	0.6667

Period	Outcome	CHE mean	Other mean	Diff. (CHE–Other)	p (two-sided)
"2018-2022"	"T_4300"	0.1778	0.1344	0.0434	0.8974

Table 7: Placebo summary: 4300 share of total tax revenue.

Period	Outcome	CHE mean	Other mean	Diff. (CHE–Other)	p (two-sided)
"1990-2022"	"share4300_total"	0.7786	0.3319	0.4467	0.1795

Period	Outcome	CHE mean	Other mean	Diff. (CHE–Other)	p (two-sided)
"2018-2022"	"share4300_total"	0.6458	0.3743	0.2714	0.7949

D.2 Descriptive tables (Stata outputs)

Table 8: 2018–2022 averages (Stata): levels and shares used in benchmarking.

Code	T_{4300} (% GDP)	4300 share total tax (%)	4300 within 4000 (%)	4200 within 4000 (%)
"AUS"	0	0	0	0
"AUT"	0.0004	0.0009	0.0693	0
"BEL"	0.6638	1.5592	19.4708	5.9545
"CAN"	0.016	0.0472	0.4176	0.5219
"CHE"	0.1778	0.6456	8.2056	63.393
"CHL"	0.091	0.4224	7.7289	0
"COL"	0	0	0	3.8238
"CRI"	0	0	0	0
"CZE"	0	0	0	0
"DEU"	0.233	0.5926	20.114	3.6948
"DNK"	0.2738	0.6004	14.6495	0
"ESP"	0.2418	0.6659	9.4276	7.4704
"EST"	0	0	0	0
"FIN"	0.322	0.7562	21.9436	0
"FRA"	0.6772	1.4909	17.3108	2.1268
"GBR"	0.252	0.7513	6.3336	0
"GRC"	0.1062	0.2647	3.5738	22.0285
"HUN"	0.0196	0.0551	2.1175	13.2022
"IRL"	0.1362	0.662	12.3526	0
"ISL"	0.2394	0.6735	11.9152	0.0498
"ISR"	0	0	0	0
"ITA"	0.043	0.1015	1.7542	0.9138
"JPN"	0.4566	1.3896	17.348	0
"KOR"	0.5504	1.9192	14.9378	0
"LTU"	0.0044	0.0142	1.4785	0
"LUX"	0.1632	0.4215	4.2383	74.2274
"LVA"	0.0384	0.1241	4.2819	0
"MEX"	0	0	0	0
"NLD"	0.2464	0.6418	15.9194	0
"NOR"	0.0014	0.0035	0.1244	41.6178
"NZL"	0	0	0	0
"OECD_REP"	0.1356	0.4025	7.4179	8.7856
"POL"	0.015	0.0424	1.1878	0
"PRT"	0	0	0	0
"SVK"	0	0	0	0
"SVN"	0.025	0.0665	4.0743	0
"SWE"	0	0	0	0
"TUR"	0.0252	0.1098	2.6482	0
"USA"	0.1318	0.5082	4.4542	0

Table 9: 2018–2022 split within 4300 (Stata): inheritance vs gifts (where available).

Code	Inheritance/residual (%)	Gifts/residual (%)	Gifts reported (%)
"AUT"			
"BEL"	81.1088	18.8912	18.8912
"CAN"	100	0	0
"CHE"	100	0	
"CHL"			
"DEU"	87.9931	12.0069	12.0172
"DNK"			
"ESP"			
"FIN"	81.0323	18.9677	18.9441
"FRA"	82.049	17.951	17.9563
"GBR"	100	0	0
"GRC"			
"HUN"	83.5052	16.4948	16.3265
"IRL"	94.7059	5.2941	5.2863
"ISL"	100	0	0
"ITA"			
"JPN"			
"KOR"	43.6205	56.3795	56.359
"LTU"	100	0	0
"LUX"	100	0	0
"LVA"	100	0	0
"NLD"	100	0	0
"NOR"	100	0	0
"POL"			
"SVN"			
"TUR"			
"USA"			

Note: The OECD sub-code 4320 (inter-vivos gifts) is not consistently reported. When a separate gifts series is unavailable, the inheritance–gifts split should be interpreted as residual / not separately identified.